
Chapter 1 - Welcome to the Toolkit

Learning Objectives

After completing this chapter, you should be able to:

- Understand the purpose of the B2B Readiness Toolkit.
- Recognise what success looks like at an international trade event.
- Approach meetings with international buyers confidently and realistically.

Why This Toolkit?

The Bird Watchers' Association, The Gambia has earned a strong reputation through the knowledge, professionalism and hospitality of its licensed bird guides. International trade events such as Global Birdfair provide an opportunity to share that expertise with specialist tour operators, bird clubs, travel media and conservation organisations from around the world.

Guiding visitors and meeting international buyers are different skills, but they are built on the same foundation: knowledge, trust and good communication. This toolkit has been developed to help participants present their experience confidently, communicate effectively and build long-term professional relationships.

Although prepared for Global Birdfair 2026, the guidance is intended to remain useful for future trade fairs, online meetings, familiarisation visits and conversations with international tourism partners.

What This Toolkit Covers

The following chapters will help you:

- Understand who attends international trade events and what they are looking for.
- Present yourself, your guiding experience and The Gambia with confidence.

- Explain your birdwatching products and itineraries clearly.
- Conduct productive B2B meetings.
- Follow up professionally after the event to build lasting partnerships.

The focus is practical rather than theoretical. Each chapter includes examples, tips and exercises that can be applied immediately.

> **Guide's Tip**
>
> You are already an experienced bird guide. The purpose of this toolkit is not to teach you how to guide—it is to help you communicate your expertise to an international audience.

What Does Success Look Like?

A successful trade fair is not measured by how many brochures you hand out or business cards you collect. Instead, success comes from starting conversations that continue after the event.

One good meeting may lead to:

- a follow-up online meeting;
- a request for an itinerary or quotation;
- inclusion in a future tour programme;
- or the beginning of a long-term partnership.

Focus on building trust rather than trying to secure immediate business.

Key Message

International buyers are looking for knowledgeable local partners they can trust—not perfect sales presentations.

Before You Move On

Remember

Your knowledge and experience are your greatest strengths. This toolkit will help you present them with confidence.

Try This

Introduce yourself in 30 seconds without mentioning bird species. Explain who you are, your experience as a guide and what makes birdwatching in The Gambia special.

Checklist

☐ I understand the purpose of this toolkit.

☐ I know what I hope to achieve from a B2B meeting.

☐ I am ready to represent both my own guiding experience and the Bird Watchers' Association.

Chapter 2

Understanding Your Future Partners

Learning Objectives

After completing this chapter, you should be able to:

- Recognise the different organisations you are likely to meet at international trade events.
- Understand what different partners are looking for when considering a destination.
- Adapt your conversations to build long-term professional relationships.

Every Conversation is Different

As part of this project, a wide range of specialist birdwatching tour operators, wildlife travel companies, conservation organisations and industry partners were reviewed to identify potential opportunities for the Bird Watchers' Association. While every organisation has its own business model and interests, most fall into a few broad categories.

Recognising who you are speaking with will help you ask better questions, share more relevant information and have more productive conversations.

Organisations Already Selling The Gambia

Many specialist bird tour operators already include The Gambia within their programmes. Examples include Naturetrek, Birdfinders, Heatherlea Birdwatching, Rockjumper Birding Tours, Oriole Birding, Limosa Holidays and Wildlife Worldwide.

These organisations already understand the destination. Rather than convincing them that The Gambia is worth visiting, your conversation should focus on how you and the Bird Watchers' Association can add value.

This might include:

- new itineraries or birding locations;
- specialist guiding expertise;
- photography-focused departures;
- seasonal opportunities;
- or improvements to the visitor experience.

> **Guide's Tip**
>
> When meeting an existing Gambia operator, avoid spending the entire meeting explaining the destination. Instead, ask what they are looking for and how you can help improve their programmes.

Organisations Exploring New Destinations

Many birdwatching companies specialise in destinations across Africa but do not currently offer tours to The Gambia. Others may have considered the destination but are looking for the right local partner before developing a programme.

Examples include operators such as Birds Wildlife & Nature Tours, Birder.Travel, 2by2 Holidays and other specialist wildlife companies.

For these conversations, your objective is to introduce the destination, understand their interests and explore whether The Gambia could complement the destinations they already offer.

Regional and Conservation Partners

Not every valuable conversation will be with a tour operator.

Regional organisations, conservation groups and industry partners can all play an important role in increasing awareness of birdwatching in The Gambia. Organisations such as African Bird Club and Fauna & Flora, for example, may contribute through conservation partnerships, publications, training opportunities or introductions to wider professional networks.

These meetings are an opportunity to exchange ideas, build relationships and identify areas for future collaboration.

Asking Better Questions

One of the easiest ways to build rapport is to begin by understanding your partner's business.

Instead of immediately describing your services, consider asking questions such as:

- What types of birdwatching tours do your clients enjoy most?
- Are you looking to expand into new destinations?
- What qualities do you value in a local guiding partner?
- What challenges have you experienced when operating birdwatching tours?
- How can we best support your programmes in The Gambia?

Listening carefully often provides more valuable information than delivering a long presentation.

Example

Meeting with Naturetrek

Rather than explaining why The Gambia is a good birdwatching destination, ask how demand has changed in recent years and what opportunities they see for new itineraries or specialist departures. This shifts the conversation from promotion to partnership.

Meeting with African Bird Club

Focus on conservation, guide development and opportunities to promote Gambian birdwatching through shared projects and member engagement, rather than discussing tour prices or logistics.

Key Message

The best B2B conversations begin with understanding your partner's needs before explaining your own services.

Before You Move On

Remember

Different organisations attend trade events for different reasons. The more you understand their objectives, the easier it becomes to identify opportunities for collaboration.

Try This

Choose three organisations you hope to meet and spend five minutes reviewing each of their websites. Identify one question you would like to ask each organisation during your meeting.

Checklist

☐ I can recognise the different types of organisations attending international trade events.

☐ I understand that each meeting may have a different objective.

☐ I am prepared to ask questions before presenting my own services.

☐ I am focused on building long-term partnerships rather than making an immediate sale.

3. Telling the Gambian Birding Story

Learning objectives

After completing this chapter, you should be able to:

- explain clearly why The Gambia is a compelling birdwatching destination for different kinds of international partners;
- describe the country’s birding strengths in terms of species, habitats, seasons, logistics, and guide quality;
- adapt a short destination pitch to specialist operators, general wildlife operators, bird clubs, and conservation partners.

The story in one page

The Gambian birding story is not mainly a story about remoteness or rarity. It is a story about **concentration, accessibility, and confidence**. The country is small—about **11,300 km²**, roughly **320 km** long and only **50 km** wide at its broadest—yet it combines Atlantic coast, estuary, mangroves, lagoons, mudflats, gallery forest, semi-evergreen forest, rice fields, savanna woodland, and the River Gambia corridor in a very compact area. English is the official language, the country already has an established tourism base, and the Gambia Tourism Board markets it as an affordable destination with strong nature and cultural appeal; it also highlights that the country is around **six hours from major European gateways**.

That matters in B2B conversations. For partners, The Gambia is easy to understand: a destination where clients can arrive for a short winter-sun break and still experience serious birding, or add upriver nights for more specialist targets. Naturetrek describes The Gambia as a destination offering “superlative” and “easily accessible” birdwatching, while Birdfinders frames it as one of the best introductions to tropical and African birding.

Core message: The Gambia offers a high-density West African birding experience in a destination that is compact, English-speaking, and straightforward to operate.

What birders come for

Species totals vary depending on taxonomy and whether compilers include vagrants and accidentals. The **African Bird Club** cites **approximately 580 recorded species**, while broader checklist compilers such as **Avibase** list **629 species** under current treatments. That difference is useful to understand: the destination is bird-rich by any measure, but different checklists count differently.

Just as important, The Gambia is **not primarily sold as an endemic-bird destination**. Rather, it is sold as an **accessible concentration of West African and biome-restricted birds**, mixed with strong numbers of wintering Palearctic migrants. The African Bird Club highlights birds “best found in The Gambia” such as **Blue-bellied Roller**, while KBA factsheets for **Abuko** and **Kiang West** point to nationally important Guinea–Congo forest and Sudan–Guinea savanna assemblages, including species such as **Ahanta Francolin**, **Western Bluebill**, **Green Turaco**,

Bearded Barbet, **White-fronted Black-chat**, and **Dorst's Cisticola**. On longer uppercase-upriver itineraries, operators consistently promote star birds such as **Egyptian Plover** and **African Finfoot**.

This is the distinction worth remembering in meetings:

- **Not**: "We have endemics you cannot find elsewhere."
- **Instead**: "We offer an unusually easy, varied, and high-yield introduction to West African birding, with enough specialties and migrants to keep experienced birders interested."

Habitats and signature sites

A strong Gambian pitch is habitat-led. Partners often remember habitats and site character more easily than long species lists.

Coastal lagoons, mudflats, beaches, and offshore islands. Sites such as **Tanji/Bijol**, **Niumi**, and the **Tanbi-Bund Road** area are especially valuable for gulls, terns, shorebirds, pelicans, and other waterbirds. The Tanji/Bijol KBA factsheet notes that the Bijol Islands and the Tanji mouth are the country's most important areas for gull and tern flocks and can at times hold **more than 20,000 waterbirds**; the islands are also the **only known seabird breeding site in The Gambia**. Tanbi holds large numbers of **non-breeding terns, gulls, herons, egrets, and Palearctic waders**, while Niumi is important for tern and gull roosts and wintering shorebirds.

Mangroves, tidal creeks, and estuarine wetlands. These are among the country's signature birding landscapes. Tanbi includes Avicennia and Rhizophora mangrove, tidal creeks, mudflats, and adjacent lagoons; **Bao Bolong** adds freshwater marsh, saline flats, tall mangroves, and savanna woodland. The Bao Bolong KBA factsheet describes it as the country's **most diverse inland wetland** and notes regular concentrations of **20,000+ waterbirds between August and December**, alongside important mangrove species and large waterbirds.

Forest and woodland. Abuko Nature Reserve is a flagship site because it is close to the tourism area but holds the country's richest accessible forest assemblage. The KBA factsheet calls it probably the **most intensively birdwatched forest in West Africa** and highlights Guinea–Congo forest species such as **Green Turaco**, **African Pied Hornbill**, **Yellow-spotted Nicator**, **Western Bluebill**, and **Ahanta Francolin**; the Gambian government notes that **over 270 bird species** have

been recorded there. **Pirang** offers another forest fragment with nationally important forest birds. **Kiang West** adds open Combretum savanna, mangrove bolongs, and strong raptor interest, alongside savanna specialties such as **Blue-bellied Roller** and **Bearded Barbet**.

Upriver birding and riverine extensions. This is where the destination becomes more than a coastal winter break. Naturetrek, Birdfinders, and Oriole Birding all use upriver extensions to target birds such as **Egyptian Plover** and **African Finfoot**, particularly around **Tendaba**, **Georgetown/Janjangbureh**, and other river sites. This is one of the strongest ways to explain additional value to an existing Gambian operator: the country supports both easy coastal weeks and more specialist river-based programmes.

When to go and how to frame it

For most partners, the clearest answer is: **the main operating season is the dry season, from November to May, with November to March especially attractive for international clients.** The Government of The Gambia and African Bird Club both point to the dry season as the most practical period, with African Bird Club specifically highlighting **November and March–April** and advising that access is best from **November to May**, while the main rains of **July–September** are best avoided for mainstream itineraries.

For birding partners, the nuance matters:

- **October–November**: post-rain greenery, lingering breeding plumage in bishops, weavers, and whydahs, first migrant arrivals, and strong photography. Birdfinders specifically notes November as the period when vegetation is still green, some bishops and weavers remain in summer plumage, and many European migrants are present.
- **December–February**: core dry-season birding, reliable logistics, large numbers of Palearctic migrants fully established, comfortable coastal conditions for most visitors.
- **March–April**: hotter, but still productive; site access remains good, grasses die back, birds concentrate around remaining water, and some partners find visibility improves. African Bird Club still highlights March–April; a 2025 trip report notes that in **February** the habitat is already drier and grasses have died back, improving views of some

species, while local seasonal guidance points to stronger raptor concentration later in the dry season.

- **Wet season**: interesting for breeding activity and lush habitats, but harder for mainstream international departures because of heat, humidity, and access challenges.

Months	Birding highlights
Oct–Nov	Post-wet-season greenery; some weavers and bishops still in breeding/summer plumage; first migrants arriving.
Dec–Feb	Core dry season; migrants fully present; easiest logistics and strongest mainstream visitor comfort.
Mar–Apr	Hotter and drier; grasses reduced, better visibility in some habitats; good access continues.
May–Sep	Rain builds and peaks; more challenging for standard tours, though locally interesting for breeding activity and lush habitats.

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Oct-NovPost-rains greenerybreeding plumagelingersfirst migrants
arriveDec-FebCore dry seasonmigrants establishedeasiest
logisticsMar-AprHotter, drierconditionsopen views improvegood upriver
accessMay-SepWet seasonlush habitats andbreeding activityharder
mainstreamoperationsTypical Gambian Birding Year
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Show code

Talk tracks, questions, and a guide's tip

A good destination story changes slightly depending on who is listening.

Practical talking points

For **specialist birding operators**, emphasize species density, habitat variety in short transfers, reliable local guiding, and the option to combine a simple coastal base with upriver specialities. Naturetrek and Birdfinders already use exactly this logic in their Gambian programmes.

For **general wildlife operators**, emphasize winter-sun accessibility, English, short flying time, birds plus primates/wetlands/river experiences, and the possibility of soft-adventure or photography-friendly departures.

For **bird clubs**, emphasize safety, ease, flat terrain, manageable group logistics, and the fact that a mixed-ability group can still see a very rewarding range of African birds in a week. Heatherlea, for example, describes walking as generally light to moderate, with mostly flat terrain.

For **conservation partners**, emphasize wetlands, mangroves, Ramsar and KBA importance, the link between birdwatching and livelihoods for licensed local guides, and the opportunity for training, guide development, community outreach, or monitoring collaboration. The CBD national report notes **six Important Bird Areas** and **three Ramsar wetlands** in The Gambia.

Guide's Tip

Do not lead with the species total alone. Lead with what that total means: "a very bird-rich country where clients can experience coast, mangroves, forest, wetlands, and savanna in one trip without difficult logistics." That is the part partners can immediately use.

Elevator pitch examples

For a specialist birding operator

"The Gambia is one of the easiest ways to introduce clients to West African birding. In a compact, English-speaking destination you can cover coastal wetlands, mangroves, forest, savanna, and upriver sites, with around 580-plus regularly cited species and a strong mix of West African specialities and Palearctic migrants. For shorter departures, the coast works well; for specialist groups, upriver extensions add birds like Egyptian Plover and African Finfoot."

For a general wildlife operator

"The Gambia works very well as a soft-adventure nature destination: six hours from Europe, established tourism infrastructure, English widely used, and excellent winter climate. Birding can be combined with river trips, mangroves, forest lodges, primates, and culture, which makes it attractive even for clients who are not full-time birders."

For a bird club or society

"The Gambia is ideal for clubs because it offers a real African birding experience without difficult travel. Many sites are accessible from the coast, walking is usually light to moderate, and members of different experience levels can enjoy colourful, visible birds, waterbirds, raptors, and photographers' species in a relatively short programme."

For a conservation partner

“The Gambia’s story is not only tourism. Its mangroves, estuaries, coastal islands, and inland wetlands are internationally important for waterbirds and migrants, with several Ramsar and KBA sites already identified. Local bird guiding can be part of conservation delivery through training, visitor education, monitoring, and community-based stewardship.”

Suggested questions to ask partners

Ask questions that help you understand where your story fits their needs:

- “What type of clients do you currently bring to West Africa or similar destinations?”
- “Do your clients prefer shorter single-centre trips, or are they open to upriver extensions?”
- “How important are target species compared with comfort, photography, or broader wildlife experiences?”
- “Would a destination like The Gambia work better for scheduled departures, club groups, or tailor-made programmes?”
- “What do you need most from a local partner: species knowledge, group handling, itinerary design, logistics support, or all of these?”

These questions help you move from promotion to partnership.

Example conversation

Meeting with Naturetrek

Naturetrek already positions The Gambia as an accessible destination and currently promotes **monthly “Gambia in Style” departures between November and April**, alongside a longer upriver-focused autumn product. That means a meeting should focus less on “why The Gambia?” and more on “where can we add value?”

You: “I see Naturetrek already offers both shorter Mandina/Makasutu-based trips and longer upriver programmes. Are you seeing stronger demand for relaxed coastal natural history weeks, or for more intensive birding with river extensions?”

Partner: “The shorter winter-sun wildlife format is often easiest to fill, but there is still interest in specialist departures.”

You: “That makes sense. On our side, we can support both formats. For shorter weeks we can strengthen coast-based days in places like Abuko, Tanbi, and mangrove creeks. For specialist groups, we can build upriver days more clearly around Egyptian Plover, African Finfoot, and photography-friendly river birding.”

This is a stronger conversation than simply repeating that The Gambia has many birds. It shows that you understand the operator’s existing product and are thinking like a local partner.

Before you move on

Key Message: *The Gambian birding story is strongest when you present it as a compact, high-yield, easy-to-operate West African destination—not just a long species list.*

Remember

The Gambia’s real advantage is the combination of **bird richness, habitat variety, access, and guide expertise** in a country that is easy for international partners to understand and operate.

Try This

Practice two versions of your destination story:

1. a **30-second version** for a specialist operator;
2. a **45-second version** for a general wildlife operator who may not know much about birding in West Africa.

Checklist

- I can explain why The Gambia is different from larger, more complicated African birding destinations.
- I can describe the country by habitat, not only by species.
- I know the main operating seasons and how they affect the birding story.
- I can adapt my pitch for specialist operators, wildlife operators, bird clubs, and conservation partners.

- I can explain how local guide expertise improves the visitor experience.

Chapter 4. Presenting Yourself Professionally

"International buyers are meeting dozens of operators over two or three days. They may only remember a handful. A clear introduction, confident communication, and genuine enthusiasm often leave a stronger impression than a long sales pitch."

Why First Impressions Matter

The first minute of a meeting often shapes everything that follows.

Buyers are asking themselves:

- Is this guide professional?
- Do they understand international visitors?
- Can I trust them with my clients?
- Are they easy to communicate with?
- Do they genuinely know their destination?

You do not need to sound like a salesperson. The goal is to sound knowledgeable, organised and enthusiastic.

Introducing Yourself

Most introductions should follow a simple structure.

1. Your name

2. Your role

3. Your experience

4. What makes your guiding special

Example:

> Hello, I'm Lamin Sidibeh from the Bird Watchers' Association, The Gambia. I've been guiding birdwatchers for more than twelve years across forests, wetlands and coastal habitats throughout the country. I particularly enjoy helping visitors find West African specialties while sharing information about local wildlife and conservation.

Notice that this introduction is:

- short
- personal
- specific
- confident

Your 30-Second Introduction

At Birdfair you will often have only 30 seconds before someone decides whether to continue the conversation.

Aim to answer four questions:

Who are you?

Who do you work with?

What do you offer?

Why is it interesting?

Example:

> Hello, I'm Pa from the Bird Watchers' Association, The Gambia. We represent licensed bird guides across the country and organise tailor-made birdwatching experiences for international visitors. The Gambia is one of Africa's easiest birding destinations, with over 550 bird species in a compact country, and we work closely with overseas tour operators to create memorable birding holidays.

Practice Exercise

Write your own 30-second introduction.

Try saying it aloud.

Time yourself.

Can you say it comfortably in under 30 seconds?

Your Two-Minute Overview

If the buyer shows interest, you can expand naturally.

A simple structure works well.

Who you are

Brief background.

What your company or association does

How you organise tours.

Why The Gambia

Two or three unique selling points.

Who your typical clients are

Independent birders?

Photography groups?

Tour operators?

Returning visitors?

Invite further discussion

"What kind of birding programmes does your company usually offer?"

This turns the conversation into a discussion rather than a presentation.

Explaining the Bird Watchers' Association

Many buyers will never have heard of the Association.

Do not assume they understand how it works.

A simple explanation might be:

> The Bird Watchers' Association is the professional organisation representing licensed bird guides in The Gambia. We promote professional guiding standards, support conservation, and help connect international visitors and tour operators with experienced local guides across the country.

If appropriate, you might also explain:

- guides are licensed
- members work throughout the country
- the Association promotes professional standards
- enquiries can be directed through the Association
- the Association works closely with national tourism stakeholders

This is much clearer than simply saying "I'm from the Association."

It also reinforces one of the Association's greatest strengths: it represents an organised network of professional guides rather than a single individual. This aligns with the positioning work recommended throughout the project, particularly the need to better explain the Association's role, professionalism and guide standards to international audiences.

Explaining Your Own Experience

Avoid simply saying:

> I've been guiding for many years.

Instead, be specific.

You might mention:

- years guiding
- favourite locations
- specialist birds
- photography experience
- languages spoken
- conservation activities
- experience with international visitors

- groups you've worked with

Example:

> I've specialised in bird guiding for more than fifteen years. Much of my work is with visitors from the UK, Germany and the Netherlands, and I particularly enjoy helping photographers and keen birders find species such as Egyptian Plover, Abyssinian Ground Hornbill and White-backed Night Heron.

Specific examples are memorable.

Professional Communication Tips

Remember that buyers are evaluating how easy you will be to work with.

Good habits include:

- Listen more than you speak.
- Answer questions directly.
- Speak slowly and clearly.
- If you do not know an answer, say you will find out.
- Avoid exaggerating species sightings or guarantees.
- Smile and show genuine enthusiasm.
- Be curious about the buyer's business as well as talking about your own.

Common Mistakes

Avoid:

❌ Speaking for ten minutes without asking a question.

❌ Listing every bird species you know.

❌ Beginning immediately with prices.

❌ Criticising other guides or operators.

❌ Using complicated tourism jargon.

❌ Trying to memorise a script word-for-word.

Remember

International buyers are looking for reliable long-term partners, not perfect presentations.

Be yourself.

Be professional.

Be enthusiastic.

Be prepared.

A friendly, knowledgeable guide who listens carefully and communicates clearly will almost always make a stronger impression than someone who delivers a polished but impersonal sales pitch.

Chapter 5

Presenting Your Birding Experiences

"International buyers are not simply looking for itineraries—they are looking for experiences that will appeal to their clients and fit within their existing programmes."

Learning Objectives

After completing this chapter, you should be able to:

- Present your birdwatching experiences clearly and confidently.
- Explain how different itineraries meet the needs of different travellers.
- Discuss pricing and inclusions in a professional and transparent way.

Presenting Your Experiences

When describing your tours, avoid listing activities one after another. Instead, help buyers understand the overall experience and who it is designed for.

A strong birdwatching product should answer six simple questions:

- What is the experience?
- Who is it designed for?
- How long does it last?
- What makes it unique?
- What is included?
- Why should a visitor choose it?

Remember that buyers are thinking about their own clients. The easier it is for them to imagine the experience, the easier it becomes to include it in their programmes.

Matching Experiences to Different Travellers

Different visitors are looking for different experiences. Be ready to explain how your guiding can be adapted to their interests.

Half-day and full-day excursions are ideal for visitors with limited time or those adding birdwatching to a wider holiday.

Multi-day birding tours allow visitors to experience a greater variety of habitats and target species while exploring different regions of The Gambia.

Photography tours often move at a slower pace, placing greater emphasis on lighting, positioning and time spent observing individual species.

Tailor-made itineraries allow you to adapt the experience around a visitor's interests, travel dates, pace and birding goals. Flexibility is often one of the Association's greatest strengths.

> ### Guide's Tip
>
> Rather than saying, "We offer half-day and full-day tours," explain who each experience is designed for and why a visitor might choose it.

Talking About Prices

Price is important, but it should rarely be the first topic of conversation.

Instead of simply quoting a price, explain what the visitor receives.

For example:

- professional guiding;
- transport;
- park or reserve entrance fees (where applicable);
- meals or refreshments;
- drinking water;
- accommodation (for multi-day tours);
- flexibility to adapt the itinerary.

Being clear about what is included helps buyers compare experiences fairly and reduces misunderstandings later.

In Practice

Meeting with Birdfinders

A Birdfinders representative asks whether your standard itinerary can be shortened for clients combining The Gambia with Senegal.

Rather than insisting on a fixed programme, explain how the itinerary can be adapted while still delivering excellent birdwatching. Describe which sites you would prioritise, what species visitors could expect, and how you would tailor the experience to fit their schedule.

This demonstrates flexibility—something many international tour operators value highly.

Key Message

Present experiences, not just itineraries. Help buyers understand who each tour is for and why it will appeal to their clients.

Before You Move On

Remember

International buyers are looking for experiences they can confidently recommend to their own clients.

Try This

Choose one of your birdwatching tours and explain it in one minute. Focus on the experience rather than simply describing the route or listing bird species.

Quick Checklist

☐ I can clearly explain my main birdwatching experiences.

☐ I know which visitors each experience is best suited to.

☐ I can explain what is included in my prices.

☐ I can describe how itineraries can be adapted to suit different clients.

Chapter 6

Conducting Successful B2B Meetings

"A successful B2B meeting is not a presentation—it is the beginning of a professional relationship."

Learning Objectives

After completing this chapter, you should be able to:

- Prepare effectively for a B2B meeting.
- Lead a productive conversation with an international partner.
- Leave every meeting with clear next steps.

Before the Meeting

Good meetings begin before you sit down.

Take a few minutes to review the organisation's website and understand the types of tours they offer, the destinations they specialise in and the clients they serve. This will help you tailor your conversation and ask more relevant questions.

Before the meeting, make sure you have:

- business cards;
- a notebook and pen;
- your itinerary or product sheets;
- pricing information (if requested); and
- a phone or tablet with your website available if needed.

Being organised demonstrates professionalism before the conversation has even begun.

Turning a Meeting into a Conversation

Many first-time exhibitors believe they need to spend the entire meeting talking about themselves.

In reality, the most successful meetings are balanced conversations.

Start by introducing yourself, then learn about the other organisation.

Questions such as:

- What type of birdwatching tours do you specialise in?
- Do you already operate in West Africa?
- What do your clients enjoy most?
- What are you looking for in a local partner?

These questions help you understand where your experience and products may be a good fit.

> **Guide's Tip**
>
> Aim to listen as much as you speak. Buyers are often more interested in discussing their own programmes than listening to a long presentation.

Answering Questions with Confidence

You should be prepared to answer questions about:

- your guiding experience;
- birdwatching seasons;
- accommodation and transport;
- itinerary options;
- pricing and inclusions;
- group sizes; and
- how tours can be customised.

If you do not know an answer, it is perfectly acceptable to say that you will confirm the information after the meeting. Honest, accurate answers build greater confidence than guessing.

In Practice

Meeting with Wildlife Worldwide

The representative explains that their clients enjoy high-quality birdwatching but also expect comfortable accommodation and flexible itineraries.

Rather than immediately describing every birding site, ask a few questions about their typical clients before recommending one or two itineraries that best match their style of travel. By responding to their needs instead of delivering a standard presentation, you demonstrate that you are interested in building a partnership rather than simply selling a tour.

Finishing the Meeting Well

Always leave a meeting with a clear understanding of the next step.

Before saying goodbye:

- summarise the main points discussed;
- agree on any follow-up actions;
- exchange business cards or contact details; and
- thank your partner for their time.

As soon as the meeting finishes, make a few notes while the conversation is still fresh. Record who you met, what interested them and what information you promised to send.

These notes will make your follow-up far more personal and effective.

Key Message

The goal of a B2B meeting is not to secure an immediate booking—it is to begin a professional relationship built on trust.

Before You Move On

Remember

The best meetings feel like conversations, not presentations.

Try This

Ask a colleague to role-play a buyer meeting. Spend five minutes asking questions before presenting your own products. Afterwards, discuss what you learned about their business.

Quick Checklist

☐ I have researched the organisation before the meeting.

☐ I am prepared to ask thoughtful questions.

☐ I can answer common questions about my guiding and products.

☐ I know exactly how I will follow up after the meeting.

Chapter 7

Preparing Your Marketing Materials

"Your marketing materials should support the conversation—not replace it."

Learning Objectives

After completing this chapter, you should be able to:

- Prepare professional marketing materials for international meetings.
- Know which materials are most useful during a trade fair.
- Present consistent and up-to-date information across all platforms.

Keep It Simple

International buyers do not expect you to arrive with a suitcase full of brochures. Instead, they want clear, accurate information that is easy to review after the meeting.

Focus on quality rather than quantity. A small collection of well-prepared materials is often more effective than dozens of different documents.

Your Essential Toolkit

Before attending a trade fair, make sure you have:

- Business cards with current contact details.
- A QR code linking to your website or digital profile.
- A professional website or online profile.
- Recent TripAdvisor reviews or other trusted testimonials.
- High-quality bird and guiding photographs.
- Sample itineraries.
- A simple price sheet or pricing guide.
- WhatsApp and email ready for follow-up communication.

Each item should present consistent information, including your name, organisation and contact details.

> **Guide's Tip**
>
> Before you travel, ask a colleague to review your website and marketing materials. Fresh eyes often spot broken links, outdated information or missing details.

Digital First

Many buyers prefer digital materials that they can save and share with colleagues after the event.

Where possible, provide:

- downloadable itineraries;
- PDF brochures;
- links to your website;
- photo galleries; and
- social media or TripAdvisor pages.

A QR code is often the quickest way to share these resources during a meeting.

In Practice

Meeting with a specialist tour operator

The buyer enjoys your conversation but does not have time to carry printed brochures.

Instead of handing over several documents, you give them a business card with a QR code linking to your website, sample itineraries and contact details. After the meeting, they can easily review the information and share it with colleagues back in the office.

Key Message

Good marketing materials support your conversation—they do not replace it.

Before You Move On

Remember

Keep your materials clear, current and consistent across every platform.

Try This

Ask someone unfamiliar with your business to review your website and one itinerary. Can they quickly understand what you offer and how to contact you?

Quick Checklist

☐ My contact details are current.

☐ My website is working correctly.

☐ My itineraries are up to date.

☐ I have a QR code ready to share.

☐ My TripAdvisor and online profiles reflect my current services.

Chapter 8

Following Up After the Fair

"The meeting starts the relationship. The follow-up helps it grow."

Learning Objectives

After completing this chapter, you should be able to:

- Follow up professionally after a trade fair.
- Maintain relationships with new contacts.
- Organise your contacts for future opportunities.

Why Follow-Up Matters

Most partnerships are not created during a trade fair—they develop afterwards.

International buyers often meet dozens of organisations over a few days. A thoughtful follow-up helps them remember your conversation and demonstrates that you are organised, reliable and interested in working together.

Aim to send your first follow-up email within one week of returning home.

Writing an Effective Follow-Up

A good follow-up email should be short and personal.

Thank the person for their time, remind them where you met and include any information you promised to send, such as an itinerary, price guide or website link.

Where appropriate, invite them to continue the conversation with an online meeting.

> **Guide's Tip**
>
> Personalise every message. Mention something you discussed during the meeting so the recipient immediately remembers your conversation.

Staying Connected

Not every contact will be ready to work together immediately.

Stay in touch by:

- connecting on LinkedIn where appropriate;
- sharing occasional updates or new itineraries;
- sending relevant news from The Gambia; and
- responding promptly to future enquiries.

Professional relationships often develop over months or even years.

In Practice

Following up with a bird tour operator

One week after Birdfair, you send a short email thanking the buyer for their time and attach the itinerary they requested during your meeting. Two months later, you send a brief update about a new bird photography itinerary. Although no immediate booking follows, the operator now

remembers your organisation and contacts you the following season when planning a new programme.

Key Message

Consistent, professional follow-up builds stronger partnerships than a single successful meeting.

Before You Move On

Remember

Every follow-up should be timely, relevant and personal.

Try This

Draft a follow-up email to someone you met at a trade fair. Keep it to five short paragraphs or fewer and include one clear next step.

Quick Checklist

☐ I recorded notes after each meeting.

☐ I know what information I promised to send.

☐ I will follow up within one week.

☐ I have organised my new contacts for future communication.

Practical Tools & Templates

These resources are designed to help you prepare before the event, organise your meetings and follow up afterwards. Adapt them to suit your own style and the organisations you meet.

Tool 1: Elevator Pitch Examples

Example 1 – Bird Watchers' Association

> Hello, my name is Lamin Sidibeh and I'm a licensed bird guide with the Bird Watchers' Association, The Gambia. We represent experienced local guides and organise tailor-made birdwatching experiences across the country. The Gambia is one of Africa's most accessible birding destinations, with over 550 recorded species in a remarkably compact area. We'd love to explore how we might support your future programmes.

Example 2 – Independent Guide

> Hello, I'm Pa and I've been guiding international birdwatchers throughout The Gambia for many years. I specialise in tailor-made birdwatching experiences, helping visitors explore a wide range of habitats while searching for many of West Africa's most sought-after species. I'm always interested in building long-term partnerships with specialist tour operators.

Tool 2: B2B Meeting Notes Template

Organisation:

Contact Name:

Date:

What do they currently sell?

What interested them most?

Information requested

☐ Itinerary

☐ Price sheet

☐ Website

☐ Photos

☐ Other

Next agreed action

Follow-up date

Tool 3: Follow-Up Email Template

Subject: Great to meet you at Birdfair

Dear _____,

Thank you for taking the time to meet with me during Birdfair. I enjoyed learning more about your organisation and discussing opportunities for birdwatching in The Gambia.

As promised, I have attached the information we discussed, including our sample itinerary and additional details about our guiding services.

If you have any questions or would like to arrange an online meeting, I would be delighted to continue our conversation.

Thank you again, and I hope we have the opportunity to work together in the future.

Kind regards,

Bird Watchers' Association, The Gambia

Tool 4: Trade Fair Checklist

Before You Travel

☐ Business cards packed

☐ Website reviewed

☐ QR code tested

☐ Itineraries updated

☐ Price sheet prepared

☐ TripAdvisor profile checked

☐ Professional photographs available

☐ WhatsApp and email working

☐ Meetings researched

☐ 30-second introduction practised

During the Fair

☐ Arrive early

☐ Ask questions first

☐ Take notes after every meeting

☐ Record agreed next steps

☐ Exchange business cards

☐ Thank each contact

After Returning Home

☐ Send follow-up emails within one week

☐ Connect on LinkedIn where appropriate

☐ Record new contacts

☐ Schedule follow-up reminders

☐ Share any additional information requested